

Alice Kohler

Senior Backend Engineer -- 8 years shipping Python payment infrastructure.

Experience

Bloombox Pay -- Staff Backend Engineer (2022 -- present)

Owned the double-entry ledger service handling all merchant payouts. Rewrote the settlement path from a legacy Django monolith into an async Python service on top of Postgres and Kafka; sustained 400 TPS at peak with p99 latency of 80ms.

Rotated on-call for the payment path from year one (one week every five). Wrote seven runbooks including the definitive reconciliation playbook the team still uses. Led three incident reviews.

Designed the exactly-once event ingestion pipeline: consumer group with idempotency keys, dead-letter queue with automated replay, and reconciliation cron that catches any drift within 24 hours.

Firehose Bank -- Senior Backend Engineer (2018 -- 2022)

Built the core-banking ledger service in Python + Postgres. Contributed a small patch to pg_partman for a partitioning edge case we hit at ~200M rows. Learned formal double-entry accounting on the job.

Migrated the deposit-hold service from RabbitMQ to Kafka; handled the cutover during business hours with zero customer-visible impact using the outbox pattern.

Reason Systems -- Backend Engineer (2016 -- 2018)

First engineering hire at a seed-stage payments startup that later sold to Firehose. Wore many hats: shipped the first webhook delivery service, wrote the first Terraform, took the first pages.

Skills

Python (8y), PostgreSQL, Kafka, async/await, exactly-once patterns, idempotency, event sourcing, double-entry accounting, distributed systems (Jepsen-literate), Terraform, pytest, incident response.

How I work

Fully remote for six years across three continents. Comfortable with async-first written decisions; strong preference for design docs over meetings. Have been the on-call primary for a payment service continuously since 2018.